

MR NANDAKUMAR



Cancerous

- Vijayan and state electricity board officials conspire to award renovation contract to SNC Lavalin at a higher rate
- Consequent loss to the board and state: Rs 390 crore
- Vijayan goes to Canada but fails to get a binding agreement from Lavalin on a grant for a cancer care centre
- Lavalin gives only Rs 12 crore of the promised Rs 105 crore
- Consequent loss: Rs 86.25 cr
- LDF cabinet not informed of the agreement with Lavalin for the cancer centre

VIJAYAN (STANDING) HAS AN EDGE OVER ACHUTHANANDAN (RIGHT); CONGRESS WORKERS BURN AN EFFIGY OF VIJAYAN (BELOW); THE RS 85-CRORE CANCER HOSPITAL THAT WAS TO BE



CHIDHARMAN



SHANKAR

Achuthanandan, however, maintained a silence all this while. "Kerala waits eagerly for the chief minister to break his silence," said Ramesh Chennithala, president, Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee. All India Congress Committee (AICC) General Secretary Veerappa Moily said, "More than anybody it is Achuthanandan who knows clearly the details of the case and hence the silence." His stance also invited angry outbursts from party members at a recent conference in Thiruvanantha-

puram. Vijayan had to pacify them. "Comrade VS will speak at the appropriate time and it will not be different from the Politburo's stand," he said.

Achuthanandan, however, does differ with the Politburo. He broke his silence on January 28, saying he had conveyed his opinion and the decision to be taken to Karat. Achuthanandan declined to endorse his party's line and said the matter was being examined. "I am saying what a person is supposed to say as per the Constitution. I will per-

form the duties entrusted to me under the Constitution," he said. The chief minister has asked Karat to restrain Vijayan from undertaking his much-publicised padayatra in February to launch the CPI(M)'s election campaign, and to take punitive action against Balakrishnan—a Vijayan loyalist—for calling the ranks without party permission to protest against the CBI.

The Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government's biggest crisis was triggered by the CBI implicating Vijayan in mid-January as one of the 11 accused in the case. Though the original contract was awarded by the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) government, some questionable changes were made by the succeeding LDF.

According to the interim progress report filed by the CBI in the high court, Vijayan had hatched a criminal conspiracy with the other accused to award the contract to the firm at higher rates in violation of rules, causing huge losses to the state. It has also been found that Lavalin's failure to furnish funds for setting up a cancer hospital in the state had also robbed the state exchequer of Rs 85 crore. The other accused include three former chairmen and former members of the Kerala State Electricity Board, a former principal secretary and the vice-president of Lavalin. The Comptroller and Auditor General too had found various irregularities in the contract and even stated that the renovation did not improve power generation. A vigilance probe instituted by the previous government had implicated some officials, but exonerated Vijayan. This had prompted the UDF government led by Oommen Chandy to request a probe by the CBI.

Will the 32-month-old Government hold forth until, at least, the general elections? Difficult, if the chief minister has his way in getting his bete noire ousted from the state secretary's post. But, if it were to happen, the state CPI(M), which is dominated by Vijayan loyalists, would see that their 85-year-old rival, too, is kicked out from his seat. Whether the Politburo will change tack from being neutral to taking sides or the chief minister will forsake his much-coveted seat for idealistic and factional objectives remains to be seen. ■